

Payal, who expressed her willingness to learn archery during a video call with Vedwan and Sheetal, now had the chance to train.

The world had never seen a quadruple amputee in para archery. It was a journey into the unknown. But Vedwan had been here before — with Sheetal, who was born with phocomelia, a rare congenital condition due to which she has no arms.

Vedwan designed a special equipment for Sheetal. Her hard work bore fruit, and her achievements turned her into an inspirational icon.

For Payal, Vedwan integrated a specialised mechanism into her prosthetic and secured it to her shoulder. This enabled her to anchor the bow with her mouth and trigger the release through a sharp shoulder movement.

Watching Sheetal practise gave Payal the confidence to train, but she had to do so differently.

"In the initial stages, Payal used both prosthetic legs to shoot the arrows, but it is against international rules. Slowly, we switched to a single prosthetic limb," says Abhilasha Chaudhary, who has also been coaching Payal and travels with the Indian para archery team.

"Once she became capable of hitting 10s consistently, we had to customise the equipment so that she could perform using a single prosthetic leg. We also changed the grip of her foot. Finally, we got the equipment approved by World Archery."

After training for a year and a half, Payal competed in her first event — the Para Archery Nationals in Jaipur in January. There, she won two medals and beat Sheetal for the first time. That confidence held her in good stead in Bangkok.

"Itna bhi darr nahin lag raha tha. Ma'am pichhe se samjha bhi rahe the (I wasn't that scared. Ma'am was guiding me from behind)," says the 18-year-old about facing her idol in a global final.

After winning the women's team gold together, it was time for an individual battle. Payal led Sheetal 27-25 after the first end of three

arrows in the summit clash. But Sheetal, a year senior and far more experienced, equalised at 54-54. Another set of three arrows later, Payal was in front again at 82-80. With three more arrows to go, she led 110-107.

Sheetal shot first and opened the final end with a 10. Payal's lead was down to two as she shot a 9. Then Sheetal hit a 9 and shook her head slightly, realising she had missed an opportunity.

Payal responded with a 10. Sheetal came up with another 10 in her final shot. Payal needed only an 8 to win but matched Sheetal with a 10 to seal the victory. After the competition, Payal received a warm embrace from her senior. In a touching gesture, Sheetal helped turn Payal's wheelchair so she could face the tricolour during the national anthem.

Payal's victory is significant for Sheetal as well. "It was tough for her to take up archery. I was worried about her. I could use my feet, but she had no limbs. How will she manage the grip? But Kuldeep Sir made a special device for her. Then I felt she could do it. *Mujhe boht khushi hui thi jab usne pehla teer chalaya tha* (I was very happy when she shot her first arrow). I felt she would have to work harder, but she will manage," recalls the Paralympic medallist.

In Payal, Sheetal has also found a strong teammate. "Winning and losing is part of the game. It's good that she is here. I used to feel alone winning medals. With her, India will win more. The mixed and women's teams have become stronger," she says.

Payal is back to her daily routine at the academy — a place Sheetal left last year to train in Patiala under Gaurav Sharma after a World Archery rule change made it illegal for the heel to touch the bow.

About her family's reaction to the win, she says, "My parents are really happy because earlier people used to say, '*Kuchh nahin kar payegi*' (She won't be able to do anything) about me. I have proved them wrong."

Her parents, along with her two younger siblings, visit her in Katra



Adaptive precision: Earlier, Payal used both prosthetic legs to shoot arrows, but later switched to a single prosthetic limb to comply with international regulations.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

sometimes and watch her train.

Payal, one of the 10 per cent differently abled students at the academy, trains from 7:30 a.m. alongside able-bodied archers. The post-lunch session runs from 2:30 p.m. to 6 p.m.

"Training with able-bodied archers has a positive effect on para archers' performance," says Abhilasha.

She believes Payal can follow Sheetal, who made history last year by qualifying for the able-bodied national squad for the Asia Cup in Jeddah after finishing third among more than 60 compound women archers in the trials.

For now, Payal's goal is to prepare for this year's Asian Para Games and eventually win gold at the Los Angeles Paralympics in 2028.